
End of the World and Hard-Boiled Wonderland review – Murakami's marvel brilliantly brought to life

Barbican theatre, London

With a dual narrative set in Tokyo and a world of dreams, Philippe Decouflé's epic production is as bewitching as its balletic unicorns

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Beautiful but dangerous ... Kiita Komagine and Misato Morita in End of the World and Hard-Boiled Wonderland. Photograph: Tristram Kenton/The Guardian

How to stage Haruki Murakami's epic, dual-narrative novel without leaving the audience in a muddle? Director-choreographer Philippe Decouflé goes big, filling the enormous Barbican stage with a kaleidoscope of dream worlds for Ako Takahashi's adaptation. It could have become a scramble of stories and inquiries into memory, technological advances in society and the imagination. Instead, it is turned into one long immaculate coup de théâtre.

There are two versions of the protagonist, Watashi (Tatsuya Fujiwara) – one is in Tokyo, the other in a world comprising dreams. The city is noirish while the latter is beautiful but dangerous, with a complicated storyline involving the sundering of humans from their shadows, a walled city, roaming animals and a professor (Narushi Ikeda) who collects their skulls to channel past experiences through sound.



Rabbit hole of wonderlands ... Miu Tomita plays Woman in Pink and Tatsuya Fujiwara is Watashi. Photograph: Tristram Kenton/The Guardian

The professor's 17-year-old granddaughter (Miu Tomita) accompanies Watashi in Tokyo and appears like a kitsch version of the prophetess who goes with Aeneas into the underworld. Watashi seeks escape, so he can be reunited with his shadow (Shuntaro Miyao), but is drawn to this strange world too and has a romance with a librarian (Misato Morita).

Initially, it spirals into a rabbit hole of wonderlands, with kooky humour and references to western canonical and pop culture, as is Murakami's way, from ancient myth to Lewis Carroll's Alice and Luis Buñuel's Un Chien Andalou. A playful set, designed by K Ishihara, shows its own theatrical construction with cheeky playfulness.

The visual pyrotechnics suck you in, from big projections to the speed, flow and agility of dancing that gestures at anime. They bring forth Murakami’s many creatures, from underground “murks”, with porcupine spikes, who flip and cartwheel, to a herd of balletic unicorns.

Decouflé’s choreography is unsurpassable in its elastic grace and athleticism without seeming circus-like. The aesthetics on the whole are so ravishing that it doesn’t matter if the story is not easy to grasp in the first half. At least not for some because, while Murakami fans will know that the unity of the story is to come, initiates to his work may be left punch-drunk and befuddled by the onslaught of worlds and images.

It becomes clear after the interval that this is controlled and deliberate confusion, reflecting Watashi’s state of mind. The dance becomes imbued with feeling as Murakami’s world reveals its underlying themes of loneliness, grief, the fear of disappearing and of death.

But the story of lost shadows, representing the “true” self, bears bigger socio-political echoes that feel contemporary, and even prescient (the book was published in 1985). This world looks like Neo’s in *The Matrix*, and its technology chimes with ideas in Naomi Klein’s book, *Doppelganger: A Trip into the Mirror World*. The sinister side of the perfectionism that this dream society has cultivated could be a comment on postwar Japan, or on our world of AI, real and fake selves, code and machine-constructed subjectivity.

At almost three hours, it leaves you with the sense that you have been dreaming, collectively, about a world of dead animals, lost shadows and unfeeling humans, but also of unicorns, impossible beauty and an ocean-like imagination. It is both of our world, and other.

At Barbican theatre, London until 11 October

生词标注（新闻高频 + 词汇第二义项）

词	词性	中文	备注
epic	adj. / n.	史诗般的、宏大的； （长篇）史诗作品	“Murakami’s epic, dual-narrative novel” 村上那部史诗般的双 线叙事小说；新闻中 常形容“规模宏大”的 事业或事件

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adaptation	n.	改编（作品）	“Ako Takahashi’s adaptation” 高桥阿古的舞台改编；动词 adapt（适应、改编），文艺新闻高频
scramble	n. / v.	混乱的一团、杂乱的拼凑；（慌忙）争抢	“could have become a scramble of stories” 本可能沦为一堆故事的杂乱拼凑；第二义项“争抢”，如 a scramble for tickets
immaculate	adj.	完美无瑕的、无可挑剔的	“one long immaculate coup de théâtre” 一场漫长而完美的舞台奇观；源自“无斑点、无瑕疵”，评论文字高频
coup de théâtre	n.（法语借词）	（剧场式）妙招、出人意料精彩一招	“immaculate coup de théâtre” 精妙绝伦的戏剧奇招；字面意为“剧院的击打”，文艺评论常用
protagonist	n.	主人公、主角	“two versions of the protagonist, Watashi” 主人公“我”的两个版本；文学核心词，对立词 antagonist（对手）
noirish	adj.	黑色电影风格的、阴郁低沉的	“The city is noirish” 这座城带着黑色电影气质；源自 film noir（黑色电影）
kitsch	n. / adj.	媚俗（作品）、俗艳的	“a kitsch version of the prophetess” 一个媚俗版的女先知；现代艺术与评论常用词
canonical	adj.	经典的、被奉为正典的	“western canonical and pop culture” 西方经典与流行文化；canon 本义“教规、正典”，人文学科高频
cheeky	adj.	俏皮的、嬉皮笑脸的（英式口语）	“shows its own theatrical construction

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			with cheeky playfulness” 带几分俏皮地亮出自己的舞台机关；英式幽默常用
pyrotechnics	n.	炫技、（视觉上的）华丽效果；烟花	“The visual pyrotechnics suck you in” 视觉特效炫目，让你沉浸其中；本义“烟火”，引申为“炫技”
gesture at	phr.	指向、示意、点到	“dancing that gestures at anime” 带有动画意味的舞动；gesture 由“手势”引申为“示意、指向”
ravishing	adj.	令人倾倒的、惊艳的	“The aesthetics on the whole are so ravishing” 整体美学令人目眩神迷；文学评论高频，语气强于 beautiful
punch-drunk	adj.	晕头转向的、被打懵的	“may be left punch-drunk and befuddled” 可能被砸得晕头转向、不知所措；源自拳击“被打得神志恍惚”
onslaught	n.	猛烈冲击、连续不断的攻势	“the onslaught of worlds and images” 世界与影像的轮番轰炸；新闻中常见 the onslaught of bad news
interval	n.	（英式）幕间休息；间隔	“It becomes clear after the interval” 幕间休息之后才明白；英式剧场用法，美式作 intermission
imbued	v.	be imbued with 充满、浸染着	“The dance becomes imbued with feeling” 舞蹈渐渐浸满情感；常用被动 be imbued with
prescient	adj.	有先见之明的、先于时代的	“that feel contemporary, and even prescient” 显

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			得切合当下，甚至先于时代；名词 prescience（先见）
chime with	phr.	与.....呼应、契合	“its technology chimes with ideas in Naomi Klein’s book” 其中技术与娜奥米·克莱恩书中的观点相呼应； chime 本义“钟鸣”
cultivated	v.	养成、培育（态度、习惯）	“the perfectionism that this dream society has cultivated” 这个梦境社会养成的完美主义； 第二义项，另义“耕种”